By the 50s Delhi had reverted to becoming a patchwork of cities rather like what Ibn Batuta had witnessed six centuries earlier. There was Old Delhi, including Shahjehanabad and Civil Lines. Then there was Lutyens's Delhi, which was dominated by the national government. As already discussed, there were also the numerous refugee resettlement colonies[19]. Soon, the city had to deal with yet another influx—that of civil servants and public sector employees needed to run the centrally-planned, socialist economy. The Public Works Department (PWD) went into overdrive and created whole new government colonies. This led to the construction of Bapanagar, Kakanagar, Satya Marg, Moti Bagh and many others. In the seventies, a large new township called Rama Krishna Puram was built to the south-west.

These government areas were built to standardized plans and according to a strict hierarchy denoted as AB, C-1, C-2, D-1, D-2 and so on. The civil servant was expected to slowly make his/her way up this hierarchy over the course of his/her career. Note that a similar housing ladder existed for the military, the public sector, university professors and even for the private sector. Smaller versions of it were created in the state capitals and in industrial townships.

As the son of a civil servant, I too spent my childhood moving up this housing ladder. Life in the government colonies had its pros and cons. Design and maintenance was poor. Painted in lime-wash, the walls flaked off to the touch. The doors and windows expanded and contracted with the seasons—one had to master special techniques to open and close each of them. At the same time, housing for the more senior officials, at least, was spacious, centrally located and had access to parks and other amenities. One interesting aspect of this hierarchical system was the fact that everyone moved up the system at about the same rate. This meant that one grew up with roughly the same group despite changing homes every few years.

By the late eighties, the children who had grown up in this system began to marry each other irrespective of their origins. Till then the Indian middle class had been made up of the Tamil middle class, the Bengali middle class, the Punjabi middle class and so on. I am not suggesting that they were not